

Depending on who theorizes, the answer to a situation that entails the ascent of a leader exhibiting undemocratic and dictatorial behavior varies. In Communicative Power, Hannah Arendt claims that due to the power gained through their actions as a collective unit, the masses are able to counteract the dictator-esque leader. Through his work in Who Governs, Robert Dahl explains that through specific conditions supported by upholding the democratic creed and the utilization of slack resources, the majority of the population can prevent a leader's abuse of power. Comparatively, within the explanations of his experiments in The Perils of Obedience, Stanley Milgram argues that obedience to an authoritative figure is a natural human instinct, therefore inhibiting citizens' ability to oppose it.

The main feature of Arendt's argument emphasizes the degree to which the masses are united. Through these observations, it can be discerned that in order to successfully challenge an undemocratic leader, the relationship among the citizenry must be collaborative and unanimous. Arendt expresses a democratic and communal attitude as she suggests that "the strength of opinion, that is, the power of the government, depends on numbers." In order to coalesce there must be a shared interest, which may be to either support or be against an undemocratic leader. By uniting as a collective group with a common goal people increase their ability to exert influence, since in a democratic republic "the people are supposed to rule those who govern them" since "it is the people's support that lends power to the institutions of a country" (Arendt, 1963, 62). This simple transference of support is how the government and its laws were established and maintain validity. Therefore, cementing the importance and the significance of the role of the masses in controlling the political arena and climate. The rise and preservation of an undemocratic leader's status and "authority require respect for the person or the office" (Arendt, 1963, 65). As soon as the respect is weakened, as too is the power of the political institution through which they operate since these institutions are "manifestations and materializations of power" meaning "they petrify and decay as soon as the living power of the peoples ceases to uphold them" (Arendt, 1963, 62). Whether or not a group unanimously views a certain leader as respectable impacts the group's power, since its capability to capitalize on it "corresponds to the human ability to ... act in concert" and "remains in existence only so long as the group keeps together" (Arendt, 1963, 64). The reliance placed on the ability of individuals to cooperate with one another creates a dependency on the masses, which could lead to consequences. However, it is because of this high degree of self-autonomy that the people are able to voice their opinions and act on them. Arendt suggests that the collaborative strength of a united front is essential to create a force of opposition strong enough to challenge the advancement of an individual's immoral ambitions.

Dahl's interpretation of the citizenry's capacity to dispute the objective of an unjust leader places dependence upon certain circumstances of the situation. The principle of Dahl's argument relies on upholding the beliefs associated with the democratic creed which keeps potentially undemocratic tendencies of an individual in check, allowing the masses to employ their resources within the properly functioning pluralistic democracy. Despite the eagerness "to attach themselves to any political entrepreneur who will cater to their tastes and desires" (Dahl,

1974, 6-7), both the masses and leaders are guided by “democratic rituals, norms and requirements of legitimacy” which shapes their actions and behavior (Dahl, 1974, 89). The democratic creed and its pillars of equality and democracy create a sense of fundamentality and duty among the populace to adhere to it. This created an environment in which “no one who denies the validity of this creed has much chance of winning political office or otherwise gaining influence” (Dahl, 1974, 95). If any undemocratic leader attempts to usurp and disregard these beliefs it is as though they are rejecting the rudimentary traits which constitute what it means to be a citizen of that nation. Therefore, in order to make any political advancements, a leader would have to promote equality and democracy, which in turn limits any possibility of immoral or unjust actions since “the creed itself gives legitimacy to an appeal to the populace,” ensuring that “no appeal is likely to succeed unless it is framed in terms consistent with the creed” (Dahl, 1974, 324). While Dahl emphasizes the significant role that the idea of the democratic creed plays in stabilizing society, he continues to explore how the people utilize the benefits of a democratic society.

Dahl highlights that due to the furtherance of democracy by the democratic creed, the citizenry, who have access to and capitalize on the potential of resources, is able to influence the success of an undemocratic leader and their plan. The ability to utilize resources such as time and wealth depends on one’s “available labor time” which is contingent on one’s occupation (Dahl, *Who Governs*, 306). Upon the unification of these like-minded peoples’ resources, an interest group is established, which due to its pooled assets can enact its preferences into the political stratum. However, the successful amalgamation and employment of resources for political motives may be hindered since “most citizens use their resources for purposes other than gaining influence over government decisions” which creates a “gap between their actual influence and their potential influence,” otherwise referred to as slack (Dahl, 1974, 305). While slack may appear as beneficial to the undemocratic leader since people are not politically active and therefore are less imposing, Dahl points out that “every citizen in the community has access to unused political resources” so if they were to trigger those with unused resources “into using its political resources at a markedly higher rate in opposition to [their] policies” it would severely harm their goals (Dahl, 1974, 309). Furthermore, by exercising their agreed upon “basic rights, duties and procedures” (Dahl, 1974, 311), such as voting, citizens ensure their voice is heard. It is through these elections that the masses’ preferences influence “the decisions of leaders” by attempting to determine “what they think are, will be, or have been the preferences of their constituents” (Dahl, 1974, 89-90). Dahl places emphasis on the pluralistic nature of democracy, which allows him to claim that the checks and balances established inhibit any progression of undemocratic policies.

Diverging from Arendt’s and Dahl’s paths, Milgram proposes that when people are faced with challenging an authoritative figure, even an unjust and dictatorial one, they are incompetent in confronting them, since it is human nature to be obedient to those deemed as socially superior regardless of how immoral they are. Society is arranged into a hierarchy in order to designate certain roles into particular groups, establishing constraints. Obedience to authority creates an

“impulse” which overrides “training in ethics, sympathy and moral conduct” leading to the “extreme willingness” to accomplish the leader’s immoral orders (Milgram, 1973, 62). The power of obedience to authority creates a “sense of obligation” to complete the duties and responsibilities that an authoritative figure may order (Milgram, 1973, 75). Through simply the “physical presence” of said figure, the “subordinate... feels shame or pride depending on how adequately he has performed the actions called for by authority” (Milgram, 1973, 77). People undergo desensitization as they disregard the “destructive effects of their work” which are “incompatible with fundamental standards of morality.” To justify their involvement, they deny their role in developing the ensuing outcome and cast off the responsibility for the consequences of their actions by viewing themselves “as the instrument for carrying out another person’s wishes” (Milgram, 1973, 76). The perspectives and priorities of the populace are shifted from ensuring the stability and sanctity of democracy to appeasing a leader to whom they have become obedient. Because of this rearrangement of loyalty the citizenry “feels responsible to the authority directing,” however they feel “no responsibility for the content of the actions that the authority prescribes” (Milgram, 1973, 77). Milgram explores the extent to which obedience impacts the peoples’ ability to reject indoctrination and concludes that obedience to authority dissolves any connection with upholding democratic beliefs. The desire to please even the immoral authority figure trumps one’s duty to uphold democracy.

The way in which society will respond to the ventures of an individual who gravitates towards undemocratic and immoral methods to secure their position is unpredictable, but can be hypothesized about in a variety of ways. In contrast to Dahl and Arendt, Milgram concludes in The Perils of Obedience that the human psyche lacks the ability to disobey a leader’s orders because of the natural inclination to be complacent to authority. Arendt grounds her argument in Communicative Power, that the masses are able to thwart the advancements of an undemocratic leader because of the belief that upon the transformation into a collective unit, the people are able to influence the political stratum. Within Who Governs, Dahl claims that through the existence and conservation of the democratic creed and the proper utilization of resources for political purposes, the populace is able to impede the immoral objectives of an unjust individual. Each of these theories, respectively, highlights a certain aspect of the masses’ and of the leader’s political behavior. Therefore, by synthesizing the lengths to which either political actor will go to attain their goals, it can be better understood how people would react to an undemocratic leader.

Works Listed

Arendt, Hannah. “Communicative Power,” in *Power* ed. Steven Lukes. (1963)

Dahl, Robert. *Who Governs: Democracy and Power in an American City* (1974)

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